MAICON

FORWARD

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(AI-Generated Session Notes)

Build an Analytics Powerhouse with AI

Date & time: Oct. 15, 11:40 AM-12:25 PM
Track: Build



Christopher S. Penn

Co-founder & Chief Data Scientist, Trust Insights

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Session Description

In this MAICON Build session with Christopher Penn, Chief Data Scientist at Trust Insights, you'll learn how to perform sophisticated data analysis using the AI tools you already have—no coding or specialized data science experience required.

You'll explore the powerful data analysis capabilities working behind the scenes in today's leading AI platforms (like hidden back-end Python libraries) and learn how to use them to uncover insights, identify patterns, visualize data, and perform types of analysis that go far beyond simply chatting with your data.

Penn will guide you through the process step by step, showing you how to direct AI to do the technical work for you. By the end of the session, you'll have a practical AI-powered analysis toolkit and a custom-built dashboard you can continue using after MAICON.

To protect privacy and make it easy for everyone to build along, attendees will receive a sample dataset from a fictional company for use during the session. You are also welcome to work with your own company's data.

Level: Intermediate: You'll explore sophisticated data analysis techniques, but no coding experience is required. Attendees should bring a laptop and access to a paid LLM of their choice.

Key Quote

> *"If it fits in a spreadsheet, the techniques that you're going to learn today apply to it."* **- Christopher S. Penn**

Session Summary

Christopher S. Penn, co-founder and chief data scientist at Trust Insights, ran this Build session as a hands-on micro workshop, with attendees following along on their own devices using a shared prompt workbook and a sample CSV file. He opened with practical advice on choosing models, describing the model as the brains and effort as the brawn, and recommended a large model on low effort for the session rather than a small model pushed to maximum effort.

Penn framed the session around three problems: generative AI is fundamentally bad at math because it predicts tokens, both people and AI have blinders that limit them to familiar

techniques within a domain, and AI-assisted reporting reinvents the wheel every time. His answer was to have AI write deterministic Python code instead of doing math itself, to have AI catalog the analytics techniques it already knows, and to make analysis a repeatable process. He also walked through the Trust Insights 5P framework for prompting agentic models: purpose, people, process, platform, and performance.

To illustrate the blinders problem, Penn described handing Claude an award-winning agronomy paper on pairwise comparison matrices and asking where the technique applied in marketing, which pointed to social media. In the first exercise, attendees had their AI tool inventory its built-in Python libraries and map them against North American industry codes (NAICS) to produce a catalog of analytics techniques across many fields.

The second exercise applied that catalog to a Google Search Console generative AI performance export of page URLs and impressions. Penn's run chose approaches borrowed from economics, demography, and real estate, found that seven pages earned half of all impressions, and produced a report in the SAINT format: summary, analysis, insights, next steps, and timeline. He cautioned that the results reflected his own website and noted that, in his view, these citations show no correlation with search traffic.

For homework, Penn asked attendees to turn the process into a reusable skill that could run on a schedule each month. In Q&A, he advised refining the output through conversation before creating the skill, favoring vendor command line tools over token-hungry MCP connectors, connecting GA4 through its APIs, and moving to a mid-range model once the skill is built.

Key Takeaways

- **Let code do the math:** Because generative AI predicts tokens rather than calculating, Penn had the AI write deterministic Python code to produce reliable analytics results.
- **Borrow techniques from other fields:** AI defaults to familiar marketing methods, so pointing it to techniques from fields like agronomy, demography, or economics surfaces analyses marketers would not think of.
- **Inventory what's under the hood:** Penn said AI tools have between 70 and 300 Python libraries built in, and asking the AI to catalog them reveals hundreds of techniques available without installing anything.
- **Any spreadsheet qualifies:** The demo used AI visibility data, but Penn stressed the same process works for churn analysis, financial reporting, or any data that fits in a spreadsheet.
- **Turn the analysis into a skill:** Once a report looks right, converting it into a reusable skill with Python code and templates makes it repeatable on a schedule and allows a move to a mid-range model.
- **Prefer CLIs over MCPs:** Penn cautioned that MCP connectors are token hungry and recommended checking whether a vendor offers a command line tool instead.